

Miftaah Institute
Associates Program | Year 1

Below are some key reports used to support the majority opinion about Salah differences .

A. From ‘Alī رضي الله عنه

«إِذَا سَجَدَتِ الْمَرْأَةُ فَلْتَحْتَفِزْ، وَلْتَضُمَّ فَخَذَيْهَا»

(Musannaf Ibn Abī Shaybah)

Meaning: “When the woman prostrates, let her draw herself together and join her thighs.”

B. From Ibrāhīm al-Nakha‘ī (Tabi‘ī)

«إِذَا سَجَدَتِ الْمَرْأَةُ فَلْتَلْزِقْ بَطْنَهَا بِفَخَذَيْهَا، وَلَا تَجَافِ كَمَا يُجَافِي الرَّجُلُ»

(Musannaf ‘Abd al-Razzāq / Musannaf Ibn Abī Shaybah)

Meaning: “When a woman prostrates, she should press her stomach to her thighs and not spread herself as a man does.”

C. From Ibn ‘Abbās رضي الله عنهما

«تَجْمَعُ وَتَحْتَفِرُ»

(Reported among the athār preserved in Musannaf-type sources)

Meaning: “She gathers herself and keeps close.”

D. From Ibn ‘Umar رضي الله عنهما

«كَانَ يَأْمُرُ النِّسَاءَ أَنْ يَتَرَبَّعْنَ فِي الصَّلَاةِ»

(Reported in early athār and cited in fiqh manuals)

Meaning: “He used to command the women to sit in a compact (tawarruk/tarabbu‘-like) posture in prayer.”

E. From al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī / Qatādah

«إِذَا سَجَدَتِ الْمَرْأَةُ فَإِنَّهَا تَنْضُمُ مَا اسْتَطَاعَتْ»

(Musannaf ‘Abd al-Razzāq, via Tabi‘īn reports)

Meaning: “When a woman prostrates, she should draw herself together as much as she can.”

Five Salaf Authorities Used by the Majority

These figures are repeatedly cited in classical fiqh as evidence for posture differences:

1. 'Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib رضي الله عنه
2. Ibn 'Abbās رضي الله عنهما
3. Ibn 'Umar رضي الله عنهما
4. Ibrāhīm al-Nakha'ī
5. al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī / Qatādah

The 7 Practical Differences According to the Majority

Each difference linked back to the textual basis above.

(1) Raising the Hands (Takbīrat al-Iḥrām and other takbīrs)

Men: Raise visibly, sometimes up to shoulders/ears.

Women: More discreet clearance; hands raised lower and closer.

Evidence basis:

- General principle from Ibn 'Abbās: «تَجْمَعُ» (she gathers herself).

(2) Placement of the Hands in Qiyām

Men: Hands placed below or above navel depending on madhhab, elbows slightly out.

Women: Hands placed on chest, elbows in, arms closer to torso.

Evidence basis:

- Ibn 'Abbās: «تَجْمَعُ وَتَحْتَفِرُ»
- Compactness principle used by Ḥanafīs, Shāfi'īs, and others.

(3) Rukū' (Bowing)

Men: Back straight, arms away from sides.

Women: More modest bow; elbows kept close and body drawn inward.

Evidence basis:

- Reports from Salaf ('Alī, Ibrāhīm) show a pattern: women “draw in” in every lowering movement.

(4) Sujūd (Prostration)

Men: Spread arms, raise back, keep stomach lifted from thighs.

Women:

- Bring limbs together
- Press stomach to thighs
- Do not spread arms
- Keep sujūd compact

Evidence basis (explicit):

- ‘Alī: «فَلْتَحْتَفِزْ وَلْتَضُمَّ فَخِذَيْهَا»
- Ibrāhīm: «فَلْتَلْزِقْ بَطْنَهَا بِفَخِذَيْهَا»
- al-Ḥasan/Qatādah: «فَإِنَّهَا تَنْضُمُ مَا اسْتَطَاعَتْ»

«إِذَا سَجَدَتِ الْمَرْأَةُ فَلْتَحْتَفِزْ، وَلْتَضُمَّ فَخِذَيْهَا»

(Musannaf Ibn Abī Shaybah)

Meaning: “When the woman prostrates, let her draw herself together and join her thighs.”

(5) Sitting Between the Two Sujūd

Men: Sit in iftirāsh (left foot under, right foot upright).

Women: Sit compactly (tawarruk/tarabbu‘) with limbs together.

Evidence basis:

- Ibn ‘Umar: «يَأْمُرُ النِّسَاءَ أَنْ يَتَرَبَّعْنَ»

(6) Tashahhud Sitting

Men: Iftirāsh in first tashahhud; tawarruk in last (Shāfi‘ī/Hanbalī).

Women: Compact tawarruk-style in both, due to modesty.

Evidence basis:

- Same athar as above + compactness texts.

(7) Overall Body Posture in All Transitions

Men: Expansive, limbs separated, movements pronounced.

Women: Gathered, limbs close, movement discreet.

Evidence basis:

- Ibn ‘Abbās: «نَجْمَعُ وَنَحْتَفِزُ»
- Ibrāhīm + al-Ḥasan: «تَنْضُمُ»

This global principle is what the madhāhib use to justify the full set of differences.